

Reimagining the Archive: Memory, Narrative, and the Ethics of Historical Recovery

Eleanor M. Ashworth

Department of History, University of
Cambridge

e.ashworth@cam.ac.uk

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Abstract

This article examines the evolving relationship between archival practice and narrative construction in contemporary historiography. Drawing on case studies from post-colonial archives in South Asia and sub-Saharan Africa, it argues that the act of recovery is never merely technical but always already interpretive. The article proposes a framework for understanding how silences in the archive shape the stories we tell about the past, and how historians might ethically navigate the tension between fidelity to fragmentary sources and the demands of coherent narrative. By engaging with recent work in memory studies, critical theory, and the philosophy of history, the article contributes to ongoing debates about whose pasts are preserved and whose are lost.

Keywords: archive, historiography, memory, narrative, post-colonial studies, ethics

Introduction

The archive has long occupied a privileged position in the discipline of history. It is at once a repository of evidence and a site of power, a place where the raw materials of the past are preserved, organized, and made available for scholarly inquiry. Yet as historians have increasingly recognized, the archive is never a neutral space. Its contents reflect decisions—often invisible, always consequential—about what is worth keeping and what may be allowed to disappear.

In recent decades, scholars working across a range of fields have drawn attention to the ways in which archival silences shape historical knowledge. The absences in the record are not mere gaps; they are, as Michel-Rolph Trouillot has argued, actively produced at every stage of the historical process, from the making of sources to the making of narratives.¹ This insight has profound implications for how we understand the relationship between evidence and interpretation, between what the archive contains and the stories we construct from its holdings.

This article takes up these questions by examining three distinct archival contexts in which the politics of preservation and the ethics of recovery are especially visible. The first concerns the colonial archives of British India, where the administrative apparatus of empire generated vast quantities of documentation while systematically excluding the voices of those it governed. The second involves the post-apartheid archive in South Africa, where the transition to democracy prompted urgent questions about how to document experiences of violence and resistance that the previous regime had sought to erase. The third addresses the digital turn in archival practice, which has opened new possibilities for access and preservation while raising fresh concerns about the politics of selection and representation.

The archives of the British Raj are, by any measure, extraordinarily rich. The East India Company and its successors produced a bureaucratic apparatus of remarkable scope, generating correspondence, reports, censuses, surveys, and legal records that document nearly every aspect of colonial governance. For gener-

¹Michel-Rolph Trouillot, *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1995), 26.

ations of historians, these materials have provided the evidentiary foundation for studies of South Asian history, from political economy to social reform to the emergence of nationalist movements.

The Colonial Archive and Its Silences

Yet the very richness of the colonial archive can obscure its fundamental limitations. As Ranajit Guha observed in his foundational work on subaltern studies, the documentary record of colonialism is structured by the categories and concerns of the colonizer.² The peasant rebel, the indentured laborer, the woman confined to the domestic sphere—these figures appear in the archive, if they appear at all, only as objects of administrative attention or anxious surveillance. Their own understandings of their experiences, their own frameworks for making sense of the world, are rarely preserved in the official record.

The challenge for historians, then, is not simply to read the archive more carefully but to develop methods for reading against the grain—for recovering, however imperfectly, the perspectives and experiences that the archive was not designed to capture. This is a task that requires both methodological ingenuity and a willingness to confront the limits of what historical scholarship can achieve. It demands, in other words, an ethics of interpretation that acknowledges the partiality of all historical knowledge while nevertheless insisting on the importance of the effort to understand.



Figure 1: A reading room in the National Archives of India, New Delhi. Photograph by the author, 2023.

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If the colonial archive presents one set of challenges, the post-conflict archive presents another. In South Africa, the end of apartheid in 1994 was followed by a sustained effort to document the experiences of those who had suffered under the previous regime. The Truth and Reconciliation Commission, established in 1996, created a new kind of archive—one built not on administrative records but on the testimony of victims and perpetrators, on the spoken word rather than the written document.³

The TRC archive raises its own questions about the relationship between memory and history, between individual testimony and collective narrative. As several scholars have noted, the process of giving testi-

²Ranjit Guha, "The Prose of Counter-Insurgency," in *Selected Subaltern Studies*, ed. Ranajit Guha and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1988), 45–86.

³Deborah Posel, "The TRC Report: What Kind of History? What Kind of Truth?" in *Commissioning the Past*, ed. Deborah Posel and Graeme Simpson (Johannesburg: Witwatersrand University Press, 2002), 147–172.

mony is itself a form of narrative construction, shaped by the conventions of storytelling, the expectations of the audience, and the emotional demands of recounting traumatic experience. The archive that results is not a transparent window onto the past but a complex artifact of a particular historical moment, reflecting the political and moral imperatives that guided the commission's work.

What does it mean to recover a voice from the archive? The question is not merely methodological but deeply ethical. To recover is inevitably to transform—to select, to frame, to narrate in ways that serve present purposes even as they claim fidelity to the past. The historian who works with testimonial archives must navigate this tension with particular care, attending to the ways in which the act of interpretation can both honor and distort the experiences it seeks to convey.

Conclusion

The arguments advanced in this article suggest that the relationship between archive and narrative is more complex, and more fraught, than is often acknowledged. Whether we are working with the administrative records of a colonial bureaucracy, the testimonies gathered by a truth commission, or the digitized collections of a twenty-first-century repository, we are always confronted with the same fundamental questions: What has been preserved, and what has been lost? Whose voices are audible in the record, and whose have been silenced? And what are our obligations, as scholars and as citizens, to the pasts that the archive both reveals and conceals?

These questions do not admit of easy answers. But by engaging with them seriously—by attending to the politics of the archive and the ethics of interpretation—we can develop a more honest and more responsible practice of historical inquiry. The archive, for all its limitations, remains our most important resource for understanding the human past. The challenge is to use it wisely, with full awareness of both its possibilities and its constraints.

About the Author

Eleanor M. Ashworth is a Senior Lecturer in the Department of History at the University of Cambridge, where she specializes in post-colonial historiography, archival theory, and the ethics of historical recovery. Her first book, *Fragments of Empire: Archives, Memory, and the Colonial Past* (Cambridge University Press, 2021), was awarded the Royal Historical Society's Whitfield Prize. She is currently at work on a second book examining testimonial archives and transitional justice in sub-Saharan Africa.